

CONFLUENT AI DAY · NYC · SEP 3, 2026

Two kinds of agent

The kind you **call** — and the kind that
never stops watching the stream.

**A field guide to event-driven AI,
the bet under Thursday's keynote.**

Hosted by Confluent (now IBM) with the AI Collective · Tribeca 360
Keynote · hands-on workshop · 3-hour hackathon

Same AI, two postures

REQUEST / RESPONSE



**Waits to be asked.
Answers. Stops.**

you → ask →
answer → done

EVENT-DRIVEN



**Watches a live feed.
Reacts the instant
something happens.**

event → react →
event → react → ...

The unit changes from a **request** to an **event** — a fact that just happened. Receptionist vs. security guard.

Three layers, one live stream

Kafka

The log. Every event written down, in order, and never thrown away — durable and replayable.



Flink

The engine. Computes over that stream continuously — not on a nightly timer like a batch job.



Streaming Agent

The reflexes. Written in Flink SQL: reason → act → observe, over every new event — not once per API call.

You don't guess *why*.
You replay it.

REQUEST-DRIVEN AGENT

Called once, then forgets. *"Why did it do that?" → a shrug.*

STREAMING AGENT

Runs on the log. Replay the exact events it saw and watch the reasoning again. *"Why?" has an answer.*

Because Kafka **never throws the stream away**, you can rewind the decision — the real argument for event-driven AI isn't speed, it's **auditability**.

Everyone shipped an *MCP layer* in ~90 days

Confluent

Managed MCP Server — a governed way for agents to reach live data.

Snowflake

Bought Natoma (May 2026) for MCP governance.

Databricks

LakeFlow + real-time push into the same space.

MCP = "USB-C for AI tools" — one connector so any agent can call any tool.

The fight isn't **whether** to speak MCP. It's **who governs it** — access, redaction, and whether a tool's own description can be trusted.

The first AI Day as an *IBM* company

- **2011** Kafka open-sourced at LinkedIn — the replayable event log.
- **2014** Confluent founded around managed Kafka + Flink.
- **Aug 2025** Streaming Agents on Flink launched.
- **Mar 2026** **IBM's \$11B acquisition of Confluent closes.** Delisted from Nasdaq.
- **Sep 3 2026** This event — the "IBM Session" is the parent demoing what it bought.